

Add noise to combat Net pirates

Downloading music, movies or software illegally might become less appealing, if every third song or film scene was suddenly interrupted by white noise or announcements urging "next time, pay for what you take!"

This technique—circulating flawed, or reproving digital copies of songs on the Internet—has been tried by a few pop stars hoping to thwart online music piracy. Two weeks ago, a University of Tulsa professor—John Hale—and a former graduate student of his—Gavin Manes—won a patent for software that analyses and monitors illegal music swapping on file-sharing networks, and then systematically inserts decoy files into the mix.

The music industry in India, which is plagued not just by piracy issues, but copyright wrangles seems to be the ideal place for low-cost, foolproof technologies such as this, rather than the sophisticated, technology intensive ATRAC, AAC or DRM-protected WMA files used by big MNC players such as Sony or Apple.

The time seems just right for a measure such as this.

snapshot

World-wide Internet Population 2004:
945 million
Internet Population in India: 39.20 million

Source: Computer Industry Almanac

Dragon burns over 8,600 cyber cafés

China has shut down more than 8,600 cyber-cafes in two months, fearing that it will corrupt young minds. The government claims it's a crack-down on unlicensed cyber cafes that spread "unhealthy online information".

Authorities also ruled that Internet cafes are not to operate in residential areas, or

within 200 meters of primary and high schools.

Big Brother is surely big in China. As the Pink Floyd song goes: "Mama's gonna make all of your nightmares come true...Mama's gonna keep you right here, under her wing, She won't let you fly, but she might let you sing, Mama's gonna keep baby cozy and warm."

Thank you for calling, Have a nice day!

Little does Kavita who becomes Karen at her call-centre job know about the bumper stickers declaring "Opportunity Indiana", "Keep Jobs in Colorado Act".

Indian politicians and executives of companies that provide offshore services are surprisingly sanguine about the controversy. But it's election time in the US, and every trivial issue is raked up. Economics dictates business, and for every dollar spent on outsourcing, the US economy receives \$1.12

to \$1.14 in return.

And, if Gary Endelman, a lawyer at BP America is believed, 3 million outsourced jobs in the next 15 years represent only two per cent of total US employment, this year.

The best way to counter all backlash is to provide accurate information according to most Business Processing Outsourcing (BPOs). This only means one thing—it would be business as usual for India. So, keep smiling

tomorrow's technology

Bendable Computing

Bendable PCs with OLED displays that could be as thin as 0.2 mm—the size of credit card—are just about five years away, according to Sony researcher Carsten Schwesig.

Sony's Gummi Project is a testbed using a TFT display, with no buttons: You hold it with both hands and twist. In place of clicks and drags, are five states—neutral, up, down and two transition states.

Gummi enables you to select an object, follow a hyperlink, or start playback, with a transition down mapped to a zoom. Because the zoom is so natural, navigating large hyperlinked documents is faster, and selecting objects doesn't require precision. Clever use of opacity allows users to blend different maps together, or leaf through discrete, but overlaid Web pages.

quoteworthy

"It's a bug."

Google spokesman Nathan Tyler, denying rumours that Google was offering Gmail users one terabyte of storage space. Testers of the free e-mail service discovered on Wednesday that their accounts claimed to have one million megabytes of storage space.

"I was using Minix when I wrote Linux, but that's in the same sense that you are using Windows when you write your columns. Do your articles contain Windows source code because you use Windows to write them?"

Linus Torvalds, in an e-mail interview to CNET News.com, refuting claims made by a report from a 14-person Washington DC think tank, that he may have gradually replaced Minix code with Linux

"There's been an endemic problem with people logging in with unpleasant or racist names. Also blokes chatting up girls. Not bad in itself, but some are doing so in a profane and very persistent manner."

Stephen Goddard, co-editor of Ship of Fools, the webzine behind the online chapel, Church of Fools. The Internet church, launched last week, is funded with £5,000 by the Methodist Church in UK.